HOME REMEDIES

STORIES

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HOGARTH
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Fuerdai to the Max

IT IS TECHNICALLY an unhappy occasion, but I am crazy happy to see Kenny. I spot him in the crowd right away, all the way from the sidewalk of the airport. My dad's driver, Six Uncle, who is obligated to follow me everywhere now, says, "Look at that little filthy bastard," loud enough for me to hear and slams down on the horn with a balled-up fist.

Kenny's a lot skinnier than he was the last time I saw him; his hair isn't gelled anymore and it flops around the top of his head like a fin. For the first time, I think I might be bigger than he is. His expression is grim until he spots me and sticks his tongue out.

As Kenny pushes through the crowded sidewalk, I catch a nearby couple turning around and giving him dirty looks. Maybe they can tell from the brand of his suitcase or the smell of his cologne, but there must also be something distinct and

intangible; I know it because I have it, too. Some people think being called a *fuerdai*—second-generation rich—is an insult, but I don't care. The emphasis is on the *fu*, as in rich. And Kenny and I, we are *fuerdai* to the max.

Twice a year we come home to Beijing to visit our families. Usually, no matter how busy they are, our parents pick us up from the airport and together we go to town on spicy seafood at our favorite place on Ghost Street. This year we're on our own. Our parents have their reasons to be pissed off. Kenny and I are both back because we have done something really bad. It isn't even a visit anymore, since neither of us can go back to the States anytime soon.

When we were fifteen, our parents took us to Cerritos, the city they were told had the top high school in SoCal, so we could enjoy a full-on American education. Complete with American suburban life. Most of us were wards of the same Chinese lawyer couple, the ones who promised to get us into college. Our parents bought Kenny and me matching cars, laptops, and clothes, and then, even though I practically begged my mom to stay the year, left us there. The lawyer couple said we'd get used to American life right away. We had neighboring two-bedroom condos in the same complex, and a lady who never talked to us came around once a week to clean up, wash our clothes, and buy our groceries.

None of the white kids, the Mexicans, the Koreans, and the ABCs, even the ones who spoke Chinese well, wanted anything much to do with us. In class they called me Skinny Chinese Sam because there was already another Chinese Sam and

he was fat. Kenny was always our leader. Kenny was Kenny because he liked *South Park* and everyone thought he was funny. He had a way about him that made everyone stick around. Our core group consisted of the two Sams, Kenny, a crazy girl named Lily who kept us all on short leashes, and, of course, that idiot who named himself Cloud.

"Goddamn, I need a smoke so bad right now," says Kenny as he throws his suitcase in the backseat of the car.

"Six Uncle, can you give him a cigarette?" I ask.

Dad's driver pulls a soft pack out of his breast pocket and tosses it in Kenny's direction without looking at us, then gets back in the front. He's been with my dad since I was two years old; I can't even count how many times he's had to lie for me. So only he can get away with treating me and my friends like that.

"How bad was it back there?" I ask Kenny, reaching the flame of the lighter toward him. We both lean back against the car window as he takes his first satisfied inhale.

"Don't want to talk about it. Too much on my mind," Kenny says, exhaling like a dragon through his nose. "I couldn't pack my own bags. Had to leave all my stuff and run out of the house before dawn like a thief or something."

"Shit, that sucks, and you just got the Huracán, too!"

"Let's not talk about it. I'm so fucking sick of talking about it," he says, spitting on the sidewalk and wiping it away with his Nikes.

I nod my head. Fair enough.

"My mom knows you're here to get me, right?" he asks quietly.

"Yeah, but she told my mom to tell me to tell you that she doesn't want to see you yet."

"That's good," he says, "because I don't want to see her either."

"Well, I'm glad you're back, bro," I say, and I genuinely mean it. He flicks his cigarette over the car and we both get in the back. Six Uncle stares at me in the mirror and then shakes his head. I turn the stereo up with my iPhone, so loud that the sunroof shakes.

This was actually maybe only the first time in my life that I've ever truly messed up. I didn't lose money in Vegas, I didn't drag race, and I didn't have that many friends to rage with on the weekends. I took molly a few times at some EDM parties in Orange County, but who hasn't? I did once get myself in trouble with the cops. All I was doing was cruising, trying to come down. I was this close to making it home but must have fallen asleep and nearly wiped out on the mountain road. Instead of driving off the cliff, I smeared blue paint all along the retaining wall and had to ditch my car there. I figured one day I'd tell my kids, "See that? Your pops drew that."

Took me about an hour to walk home and I passed out on my bed immediately, but later, when police were inside my condo and couldn't find any parents, it became just a giant mess. I called the Chinese lawyer couple, who showed up and jabbed their fingers in my face, and called up a white-man lawyer. They said because I was over eighteen, there was a chance I'd be convicted of reckless driving and then get locked up. After

that, the lawyers told my parents that it would be better to have me back in Beijing, at least for a while.

I heard my dad talking to the lawyers on the phone, saying how much he'd be willing to pay them as a reward to cover this up. I think the more trouble I get into, the bigger my dad gets to feel for getting me out of it.

That's the only reason I already had a flight to Beijing scheduled for the morning after "the incident." By the time the police tried to find me at school, I was out of the country. They couldn't keep our names straight anyway. Zhang, Ming, Yuyao, Jirui, Kao, Duo Duo, Fung, it was all the same to the cops. They couldn't tell us apart, they didn't know if a person was missing, just thought it was one person with three names or three people with the same name. So even though I was there that night, nobody will see my name in any newspapers or getting bad press for Chinese parachute kids. Nothing about my parents, about the one-child policy, about Chinese society failing my generation. My parents didn't even seem that mad at me about any of it. It was not as if I was throwing away a bright future at Berkeley that was all lined up, they'd probably given up on that dream a long time ago.

What police reports can't say were our reasons for doing what we did. California high schools can be treacherous places. Think about it: What would you do if, on the first day of school, assholes keyed your new car because they thought you wouldn't fight back? Wouldn't you want everyone to know that you could defend yourself? Wouldn't you want revenge? Wouldn't you want people to understand that if anyone messed with your friends or your family, then you would make them pay?

Before that night, I might have done a few other things that were against the law. I may or may not have punched a kid so hard in middle school that he had to wear a brace. I admit to taking some bats to car doors after being looked at wrong. You could say I baited trouble. But the thing is, I always did what I wanted and nothing happened to me. Just good luck. What Lily asked me to do, what she convinced me was necessary, well, that was just bad luck. Especially for her, for Kenny and Fat Sam, too, but more so for fucking Cloud.

Instead of taking us straight back to my parents' place, I convince Six Uncle to let us eat first at an Italian supermarket in Shin Kong Place, where they have really good spaghetti.

Six Uncle watches us order, then pays for our food, but as soon as he heads to the bathroom Kenny and I drop our forks and get the hell out of there. We run out the back way through the hanging hams and into the mall. It is always like that with us. We could speak without even talking. We're both hysterical and panting and pulling up our pants and Kenny is leading the way, hurtling down the escalator yelling, "Emergency, ladies and gentlemen! A life is on the line!"

Now that's the Kenny I missed. In Beijing, Kenny was a legend. Kenny always had, like, six girlfriends and a limp, which he claims he got from fucking too much. He has always been lanky even though he eats like a beast. And although he was practically military royalty, he never held that over anyone's head. He was always chill, fun to be around, and even though he had lots of friends, he always called me up. Being around

him actually calms me down a lot; he is probably the closest thing I have to a brother.

Once outside, we jump in a black cab in the alley and head back up the second ring road toward Sanlitun.

"Can you take us to Kokomo?" asks Kenny. Kokomo is a cheesy tiki bar on the roof of 3.3 Mall, where nobody would know us. "I could use some sunshine right now."

I turn my phone over in my hand and take out the battery. Kenny never got his phone back after being released from the police station, but his credit cards still work, which is a relief.

"I should get hammered before I see my parents," he mumbles, as if to himself. He is looking ahead, but his eyes are all spacey. The hand with his wallet in it seems to be shaking.

It is depressing just to look at him.

"Stop being so worried," I say in the most convincing tone I can come up with. "They've heard of far worse. Kids in pool-hall shootings, killing people. I heard my dad tell your dad, 'It's not like he killed anyone.'"

I look into the rearview mirror just in time to see the driver turn his eyes away.

"My dad's not like yours."

"Yeah, you're right," I say. "Maybe my dad is just tired of getting mad. He's tired of me in general."

"I think my dad is literally going to kill himself," Kenny says, not looking at me.

"Just stick with the story. Keep saying 'It was all Cloud, that's the guy you want to question," I say. "People will forget about it eventually." But Kenny's not listening.

Kenny laughs. "You know if this gets out, that his son got

into big trouble in the States, what are people going to say? They're going to want to know where all my money came from."

I shake my head like that's ridiculous, but what do I know?

The counterfeit liquor at Kokomo tastes like gasoline and the music is terrible techno, so it is exactly where nobody will come looking for us. Kenny's scared and so am I. His nervous energy rushes through me like a wild fire looking for the next spot to burn.

We need to order a ton of beers, we yell to the waitress.

As it gets dark above us, we crowd the table with empty bottles. Kenny loosens up. He tells me about being handcuffed and driven to the police station. He tells me about not showering for four days and finding out he is actually capable of BO. He tells me about not being able to take a shit for three days and pissing in a bucket. He tells me about using his one phone call to call his "aunt" and finding out she was more scared than he was. He tells me about the rotten milk the guards threw at him and the peanut butter sandwiches he couldn't swallow. Even then, the way he tells it, it's pretty funny. The way he talks makes me think he doesn't hate me, won't blame me for what happened, at least not right now. He tells me about making bail and finding his real aunt from Florida waiting to pick him up.

"She was standing outside the police station wearing a disguise, like an actual wig and sunglasses, like she's conducting espionage in a movie," he says. I spit my beer out all over the table, laughing.

We try to remember the numbers of everyone we like in

the city, but we've been away for a long time. Plus it isn't summer vacation and nobody studying abroad would be around yet. Our friend Square is still in the international school here, and after a while he comes by, even though he never liked me and always made sure I could tell. Then Coco and Crystal arrive, these annoying girls we know from elementary school who are no fun and just shop all day.

"Kenny? Hey, Kenny. I was just thinking about you," says Crystal as soon as she sees us.

They kiss Kenny on both cheeks. They don't do it to me, but I keep my face straight.

"Yeah, what were you thinking about?" asks Kenny.

"I was thinking that, well, I haven't texted Kenny in a while, and I wondered how you were doing."

"I'm—" he starts to say, but Crystal isn't finished talking.

"Coco just went to Moscow with her mom because she had this idea in her mind that she wanted to buy diamonds," she continues. "But of course it was a big waste of time. Then I just got back from London because I. M. Pei built my dad's friend a pavilion in his backyard, but that party was boring, too. What do you guys do over there?"

"Nothing special, just going to school. Going to Six Flags. Car shows. Pretty girls. Smoking leaves," he says.

"And how about you?" I cut in. "How's school in Switzerland?"

"No, Sweden," she replies shortly. "We drive to Norway and listen to these bands in the woods and eat seafood."

"Right, right, Sweden," Kenny says, nodding, as if agreeing to something dangerous.

"Well, Kenny and I, we've been well. I keep telling Kenny

that we should come back more often," I say. "Just to keep up with you sophisticated European girls."

"So tell me," Crystal asks, "what's it like in America, is it all that great?"

"Yeah, sure," I say, looking away from her and making eye contact with the girls at the next table. "It's pretty weird."

We jump around the dance floor in a group just like the old junior high times. More friends of Coco and Crystal show up. Someone carrying a briefcase pays for a private room and like magic, the top-notch local girls line up at the railing, trying not to look in our direction, hoping we will invite them inside.

"It's still fun, right?" I say to Kenny, eyeing the girls. "Don't you kind of miss this?"

"Why aren't they asking us why we're back so early? Do they know something? Did you tell them?" Kenny asks, jerking his head toward Coco and Crystal.

"Man, nobody knows anything. They don't care," I whisper, patting him on the back.

Coco is busy lecturing the waiter, "Champagne has to come from Champagne. This shit is just sparkling wine." And the friends she brought are nodding even though they don't care and the waiter is listening even though I'm sure he cares even less. They're all flirting with this tall, muscly guy who is not paying for anything because he's someone's private tutor. He apparently went to Harvard, Yale, and Princeton, and yet he is mooching off us.

Then Kenny says he wants to "fly," so we have to ask around for Prince's new number. Prince is a collective of Nigerian drug dealers who refers to themselves as Prince. Whether this is a

sophisticated operation or Prince is actually a real person is a debate no one really wants to engage in.

"Do you want the green or do you want the white or do you want the black?" Prince says to me in English.

"The green," I yell into the phone, still loving the way my American accent sounds. We go into the bathroom together to smoke the weed and I close the door to shut out the sounds of our friends singing karaoke.

"You feel better now?" I say to Kenny as he tries to light the joint in his mouth. "It's going to be fine."

I turn on the fan and watch him inhale as much smoke as he possibly can.

"Feel better . . . that we fucked up our entire lives?" he says in between huge hits.

I think I am looking at him way too much, so I look away when he catches my eye.

"What would you rather have happened? For us to just walk away?" I say, taking the joint from him. "Was it wrong of me to try to help Lily? To stand up for one of us?"

"Oh, so that was why you made us do it," Kenny says, leaning his face on the mirror. "Thanks for that. I feel great now for fucking up my life. Probably my whole family's lives, too."

Is this a joke? Was Kenny crying or laughing?

"Hey, you were there, too. You could have stopped it if you wanted to," I say, but he's so high I'm not sure he hears me.

All five of us had walked up to this bitch named Wey in the parking lot, right by her baby-blue Maserati. We told her to

come with us to the park by the condos, we had to talk to her. I remember that part clearly: the two kids playing with that big white dog tied outside the ice cream place. Those orange-and-white clouds hurrying across the sky above our heads as we walked. Green ivy smell in the breeze. There was only one tree in the park and we gathered under its branches. I told Wey to admit she was wrong and apologize to Lily, but she gave me two miles of lip. Then I told her to beg Lily for forgiveness, but she just kept talking shit.

In her gravelly smoker's voice, this bitch said that Lily was not who she said she was. Said Lily was an escort. That her family doesn't do arms deals and they don't really have that much money and that's why she keeps the Four Seasons room because they were whoring her out. That we were stupid to be her friends, that she was using us. Wey said we were trash, too, because we went to public school. Then she started yelling, saying we were all in big trouble now for trying to intimidate her, that her family was politically connected, like that was going to scare us. The only person she scared was Cloud, who kept telling me to calm down. I told him to shut up or scram. But Cloud ended up standing by the edge of the park, waiting, maybe because he was looking out for other cars or because he was scared or didn't have a ride. The rest of us, we were all children of Somebody. Maybe not tippy top of the food chain, but still she had the nerve to look down on us and our families. Who would we be if we just let that go?

Lily pushed the bitch first and started slapping her around. I said, "Make her kneel and kiss our shoes." Then Fat Sam told her to clean up the cigarette butts off the ground with her mouth. Then Lily dumped her milk tea on Wey's head. "Admit

it," Lily said while recording with her phone. "You're a psycho and a liar. We won't let you go until you admit it."

What did Wey think was going to happen? That we would just let her get away with saying whatever she wanted?

I still remember the way that bitch looked when I grabbed her by the hair and told her to take her clothes off. Her flat ass all white as she bent over, trying to hide her floppy boobs with her knees. I laughed in her face. And then everybody started cracking up. By then she was crying, but it was too late for that. Her ugly face was smudged like a clown's. I remember Lily spitting on her and me burning her with the end of my cigarette before Kenny pulled me off. After that we were all quiet. The mood changed quickly. Walking back to our cars across the big intersection, none of us looked at one another.

Maybe Kenny thought I'd taken it too far, but I felt pretty numb while it was happening. Why should I care? Nobody cared what I did. I never had anybody to answer to. I watched my friends speed off in their cars. I remember being the last to leave. It was hard to turn the car on because my hands kept shaking.

It is still early, so I tell the server to bring some fruit platters and another bottle and to welcome some pretty girls in.

I wake up in Square's apartment. I know this because I recognize the paintings of brown rocks on the walls, which Square was telling us cost a million dollars each. Also because his mom is yelling my name.

"Minnie is on the phone and Six Uncle is coming to get you," she says with a sigh.

I give her a thumbs-up.

My parents needed me to give them English names, so I gave them a list and they managed to pick Donald and Minnie, just like the Disney characters. It makes them easier for foreign partners to remember and for Chinese clients to bypass Confucian hierarchy.

Square's housemaid leaves a bowl of congee on the coffee table and I sit there staring at it. I would be scared if Donald was on the line. I could see him having to leave his study, not having finished pouring hot water over his collection of clay teapots as if they were living things. My dad has had nothing handed to him. My grandma died when he was just a kid, but he never talks about it. In graduate school he managed to study for a year in Bologna, which is where he picked up Italian, but he didn't tell me about that either. It was my mom who told me that Dad was once so poor he ate cheap canned meat with rice for months until another student pointed out that it was cat food. How does one go from eating cat food to making himself a millionaire? He doesn't tell me when I ask. My dad never really let me get to know him. It's like he thinks he already pays for my life, so what else do I expect from him? To open up to me? I am just something he puts up with because I'm his son.

Donald used to make me porridge with the cans of sardines he always took with him on trips. He would pour on soy sauce and smash into it whatever was left in the fridge and then at the last minute he'd pour in some hot water and call it the emperor's porridge. Minnie thought it was disgusting and would open the windows. But when I think about it, I only remember how good it had tasted.

Then when I got older, he'd order takeout, always the most

expensive dishes at whatever restaurant he happened to be eating at with his friends. He always got two orders. "Because my son is a big boy." Six Uncle usually drove the food back to me fresh. Abalone steak, racks of ribs, and once a dozen live prawns still convulsing in their rice wine bath. Donald uses me to brag to his friends about how complete his life is. The way he uses Mom to show off her closet full of purses right by our front door.

My mom feels like my sister sometimes because I always remember her looking so young and fragile. In elementary school, I cursed at teachers just to get in trouble, just to see my mom's worried face outside the classroom window, coming to get me. When I got kicked out of my first school, she sent me to live with her mom and never came to visit me. That was when I felt like no matter how much I acted up, nobody cared about me anymore. I could do whatever I wanted. These days what I'm most afraid of is Mom being nice to me.

I look for Kenny, but he's not in the living room and I don't see his shoes by the door. Maybe he was right to be afraid for his dad. He was a pretty prominent public figure in the municipal government. If all the details got out, I could see it being a pretty big scandal. But as long as Kenny just sticks to the story I told him before, it would be okay. It was all Cloud. We were just watching. We couldn't stop him from doing what he did.

The problem with Los Angeles was that there's no weather and too much space. I needed the weight of a city to distract me. In the suburbs there was nothing going on, so I started focusing on the people around me, and I inevitably found somebody I couldn't stand.

It was common knowledge that Cloud's dad had been in jail for corruption since Cloud was a kid. We all knew his dad used to be Lily's dad's right-hand man. Basically that meant Cloud's education was compensation, a kind of reward for the job well done of his dad's keeping his mouth shut. We all knew this because none of our parents would stop talking about it. What a good student Cloud was. How humble. How big and strong. How respectful he was to his minders. How he was the only one making the most of every opportunity in America.

Cloud's looks didn't do him any favors either.

When he smiled, his gums showed above his teeth, like a dog's. His head was shaped like a Buddha statue's and he had an effeminate way of talking with his hands, so much that I was always noticing how clean his nails were. When we were having a good time picking out new cars, he inevitably said something to dampen the mood: "Guys, I calculated the cost of insurance for internationals. Those companies are ripping us off. You should really just explore different modes of public transportation."

When we were all talking about majoring in business in college, he said, "I am thinking of engineering. Because I think with engineering you really have a chance in this country. There's the infrastructure for all talented parties to succeed."

"Oh god, shut up already," I would say, but then Kenny kept stopping me. "No, don't tell him to shut up, I want to know. One day we're going to be visiting our boy Cloud at Harvard."

When waitresses put cans of tea with straws in front of us, Cloud never took one unless I offered, because I always paid. I didn't like the idea of visiting Cloud at Harvard.

Had the circumstances been different, I wouldn't have had

any reason to talk to him. Half the time, I was embarrassed to be seen with such a dork in public.

"They probably only need one person to place the blame on," I said to Kenny over the phone right afterward. "The white cops looking at photos won't know the difference between you and Cloud. I promise you that."

If Kenny said Cloud was the leader, I honestly thought the police would believe it since he is the biggest and tallest of all of us. When they figured out he was already accepted to Johns Hopkins early admission and, more important, a total wimp, they'd assume it was a big mistake and let everyone off the hook. It had seemed like a good idea since Cloud was the only one without the money to run back to China, and for whatever deal he had going on with Lily's dad, he would never rat her out.

So it was a huge surprise to me when they didn't let Cloud go and more shocking when they came to school and pulled Kenny, Lily, and Fat Sam out of class and took them into the station for questioning. Nobody was prepared for it to get so official. How were we supposed to know that the bitch would actually press charges?

Kenny was lucky to have gotten out of the country before he officially got charged. None of the Chinese newspapers had picked up anything about it yet. I didn't want to agree with Kenny, but this could turn out really bad for his dad if—well, I could see the headlines. If somebody really decides to push for it, I could see how Kenny's dad might get flagged for corruption and it would be Kenny's fault.

To be honest, if I were in Kenny's place and I had my family's reputation to protect, maybe I'd just kill myself.

I know where to do it, too. I've given it some thought. There's one stretch of the PCH where there isn't a single traffic light for miles. Every time I drive past, there are always flowers clustered against a pole and right where the road bends. If you were to crash there, nobody would think anything of it.

Lily somehow found out about my reckless driving case and never told a single person about it. In fact, she said I was lucky to get to start over and there was no point in making it public. That was the kind of thing that got me thinking I liked Lily. She was completely her own creation and never lost her calm, so you could count on her to step up for you. I respected that about her. A girl like Lily, with everything she had, isn't allowed to be soft. She can't just cry over a breeze.

So when she told me about that bitch named Wey trolling her online, spreading rumors about her and so-and-so's boyfriend from Vancouver, I didn't care about any of the details because she cried softly as she was telling me. It made me want to grab her face and kiss her. One summer almost a year ago, Lily invited me to visit her hotel room at the Four Seasons. It was just a room with a big bed and all these Christmas decorations still hanging off the wall. There was one of those enormous teddy bears from Costco on a pile of sheepskin rugs and half-empty bottles of water rolling around on the floor. There was nothing else to drink, which is why I think nothing ended up happening between us. Maybe people think I am very experienced with girls, but I don't really know how to talk to

them. Like if I get really wasted, sometimes I end up in bed with a girl without me having to say anything, but I don't really know how to take it there if we're both sober. I think my feelings for Lily started that night because I saw something in her that none of the rest of them saw. That she was just as lost as me and even more alone. It was then that I vowed to myself that I'd do anything for her. But she didn't have the same feelings for me, because she just saw what everyone else saw, that I could be mean and I liked fighting. There was really nothing I could do about that.

I wait until Square's mom leaves before I go looking for my shoes. When I find them I stuff my feet in without untying them. I know the servants' entrance to Square's building, so I ditch the congee bowl on a table and escape down the stairs and into the hutong entrance behind the apartment complex. I just want to go as far away as I can, but it's just then I remember I still don't have any money. My hand hurts and I stick it into my mouth. It tastes like blood and I realize there are nasty cuts on each of my knuckles. I vaguely remember Kenny and me yelling at each other, me throwing a few punches at him that land on a glass wall. I wonder what's wrong with me, what makes me keep going further and further into fucking up my relationships with people until they give up on me.

"Young man, that's going to get infected if you keep doing that."

I turn around and see an old man with a shaved head and a tank top sitting on a stool watching me. The words TEAR DOWN are painted in red script above his head.

"Come in my house and I'll give you something to wash it off with," he says.

I think it's probably better to stay off the street in case Six Uncle is looking for me, so I follow him into the shade.

It is the garbage collector's house. By house I mean it's just a room filled with trash. There must be at least ten broken fans in this place. There are three women of different ages watching a small television, and they ignore me. Pieces of cloth cover a moldy cement wall. There's a baby, so tiny it couldn't have been a year old, sleeping facedown on a bottom bunk. The baby's butt is dirty, and it's lying on an even dirtier bamboo mat. There are long ribbons attached to the ceiling fan, perhaps to keep the flies and mosquitoes flying in circles.

The old man hands me a pail of fresh water and I dip my hand in it. The coolness stings but feels good. He gives me a wedge of iodine-soaked bandage and I thank him even though it hurts to use it.

Then the little baby wakes up and starts crying at the top of its lungs. It's like a signal for the whole family to get ready for some big event. The whole house is in action. I guess it is the mom who ducks out of the room and comes back. She is holding a piece of glass, almost the size of an egg, suspended on a string. It looks like a broken-off strand of crystal from a chandelier. She holds the baby and gently swings the glass above her head. Between the television light, the sunlight, and the lights on in the house, the glass throws a thousand colors around us and, like magic, the baby stops crying.

I have to admit, if only for that fleeting moment, I feel something, too.

Home Remedies for Non–Life-Threatening Ailments

Boredom (Born from general confusion stemming from lack of clear direction/complete misunderstanding of life's purpose.)

Stay indoors, in a room with bad lighting but many makeshift ashtrays. Arrange and rearrange your comforter into various malleable structures. Stand back and give names to the newly birthed forms. Now it is a manatee. Now it is Abraham Lincoln's headless body. Now it is a giant nose. Applaud yourself for your mastery, for now you can be fairly certain of the potential you possess as a visual artist.

Write a letter to the boy named Bunny whom you met on a train in Croatia. The one who spoke to trees and set his watch to random hours as his way of time traveling; write to him that you hope he is still alive and insane. Tell him you are glad you're not him and even more glad he's no longer following you around, talking about modernism.